IB English A: Language and Literature · Paper 2

Death and the Maiden

Ariel Dorfman · A Paper 2 guide

Comparative essay preparation
Event bank · Quote bank · Issue arcs by act and across the play
Pairing notes · Self-test

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How to use this guide

Every event, claim and quotation in this guide is tied to the playscript. References take the form II.1.95: Act II, Scene 1, speech 95, counted from the start of the scene. A reference with a plus sign, such as II.1.95+, points to the text that follows that speech: a stage direction, or the continuation of a long speech. Act I, Scene 3 has no dialogue at all.

> **Built for Paper 2.** The issue arcs trace each concern through Acts I, II and III, so you can see how the play's position develops. The pairing notes at the end of the exam section show how the play sets up against *The Visit* and *The Things They Carried*.

The examination

Course and paper	IB Diploma English A: Language and Literature, Paper 2: the comparative essay on two literary works studied in the course. Paper 2 is not a set-text exam: the questions are general, they do not name any work, and there are no extracts.
Format	1 hour 45 minutes at both SL and HL. Answer one of four general questions, comparing two of the literary works you have studied. 30 marks; 35% of the final mark at SL and 25% at HL. Check these figures against your current subject guide.
Criteria	A Knowledge, understanding and interpretation (10); B Analysis and evaluation (10); C Focus and organisation (5); D Language (5). Your iSWIM P2 checklist splits B into B1 and B2.
What this means for revision	You will not know the question in advance, so you cannot prepare a single essay. You prepare a small number of moments from each work that you know in detail, grouped by issue, and you rehearse how each work handles those issues differently. That is what the issue arcs, the event bank and the quote bank in this guide are for. Comparison must be structural: every paragraph needs both works.

iSWIM for Paper 2. Use the five guiding questions on every prompt.

i	What is the issue of significance? The concern beneath the prompt's topic word.
S	Why does it matter? The human, social or philosophical stakes.
W	What does each author want you to understand about it?
I	How does each author get you to understand it? Structure, form, characterisation, voice, staging.
M	What does each work position its audience towards, and what does the comparison reveal? The essay-level M comes from the tension between M(A) and M(B).

Write each paragraph with PEACE ACT: Point, Evidence, Analysis, Comparison, Extension, Audience, Context, Tie-back. Characters do not exist: reach through Paulina, Gerardo and Roberto to the choices Dorfman makes with them.

iSWIM tells you how to plan. Thinking with iSWIM tells you how to think. Your text-type guide tells you what to notice and what to call it.

Context

Facts about the writer and period are attributed to a named source. Facts about the work come from the work.

Where and when

The play names no country. The characters refer to seventeen years of dictatorship I.1.82 and to Paulina's ordeal fifteen years earlier II.1.41, and she dates the arrest to 6 April 1975 III.1.56. The new government's Investigating Commission and the threat from the Army I.2.39 place the action in a transition from military rule. The DATM revision notes read it as post-Pinochet Chile.

Source: Playscript; DATM revision notes

Theatrical lenses

The DATM lens files read the play through Brecht (the mirror and the refusal of catharsis), Arendt (the banality of the functionary), Kafka (the process without a verdict) and Voltaire. These are interpretive frames to test against the play, not facts about Dorfman's intentions.

Source: DATM lens files 04–06

At a glance

Scene	Setting	Events	Event titles
Scene I.1	Beach house, after midnight	E1–E1	Gerardo comes home late
Scene I.2	The same, later that night	E2–E2	Roberto arrives
Scene I.3	Wordless: Paulina ties Roberto up	E3–E3	The wordless scene
Scene I.4	Before dawn	E4–E4	The accusation
Scene II.1	Midday	E5–E6	The trial and the terms; The dead and the living
Scene II.2	Afternoon	E7–E7	Gerardo and Roberto
Scene III.1	Evening into dawn: the confession	E8–E12	The old wound; Paulina's testimony; The confession; The test; The mirror
Scene III.2	A concert hall, months later	E13–E13	The concert

Event bank

13 numbered events in order. Read one scene for close revision, or E1 to E13 straight through as the arc of the whole work.

Scene I.1

E1 Gerardo comes home late I.1.2–89

Paulina, alone with a gun, waits for Gerardo I.1, opening+. He explains a flat tyre and a stranger who gave him a lift I.1.6. The real subject is the president's Investigating Commission: Paulina points out that it only investigates cases that ended in death I.1.64.

Why it matters. The play opens on the limits of the new state's justice before the doctor arrives. The gun is on stage in the first minute.

Scene I.2

E2 Roberto arrives I.2.2–58

The stranger, Dr Roberto Miranda, returns late at night, having heard Gerardo's name on the news I.2.11. Over drinks the men discuss whether the Commission can work I.2.39, and Roberto quotes Nietzsche on the female soul I.2.22. Gerardo invites him to stay the night.

Why it matters. The audience hears the details Paulina will later claim to recognise before it knows they matter.

Scene I.3

E3 The wordless scene I.3, opening+

Paulina takes the gun and goes into Roberto's room; there is a muffled cry I.3, opening+. When his own headlights sweep the room, Roberto is revealed tied to a chair and gagged I.3, opening+.

Why it matters. Dorfman stages the turning point without a word, and shows the result only as an image in a flash of light.

Scene I.4

E4 The accusation I.4.1–54

Paulina plays Roberto's cassette of Schubert's Death and the Maiden I.4.1+. She tells Gerardo that this is the doctor who played Schubert while she was tortured I.4.13 and announces a trial in the house I.4.54.

Why it matters. The private trial begins as a parody of the courts the new state cannot use.

Scene II.1

E5 The trial and the terms II.1.7–95

Paulina records everything on the cassette recorder II.1.7. Gerardo threatens that she will have to kill him first II.1.39 and warns how the press will use the episode against the Commission II.1.67. Paulina names what she wants: a confession II.1.95.

Why it matters. The private conflict is framed in the public stakes of the transition.

E6 The dead and the living II.1.68–104

Paulina argues that the Commission deals only with the dead, and she can speak II.1.68. Gerardo tells her she has stayed a prisoner for fifteen years II.1.79. She sends him to persuade Roberto II.1.104.

Why it matters. The play sets the institution against the survivor's need to be heard.

Scene II.2

E7 Gerardo and Roberto II.2.21–39

Alone with Gerardo, Roberto pleads innocence and offers innocent reasons for his Schubert cassette II.2.21. Gerardo proposes indulging her II.2.39: a confession, invented if necessary.

Why it matters. The lawyer coaches a confession, so the play makes its own evidence doubtful.

Scene III.1

E8 The old wound III.1.8–17

Paulina and Gerardo return to the night she came home after her release and a woman came out of his bedroom III.1.9. Gerardo's defence is that he was looking for her and is also human III.1.14.

Why it matters. The man who speaks for law and reconciliation is shown asking forgiveness for his own betrayal.

E9 Paulina's testimony III.1.51–56

Gerardo records Paulina telling her story as if in front of the Commission III.1.52, beginning with her name and the date of her arrest, 6 April 1975 III.1.56.

Why it matters. The private trial becomes a rehearsal of the testimony the state will not hear from her.

E10 The confession III.1.57–65

Roberto's confession is heard in the dark, describing the Schubert as a way of gaining prisoners' trust III.1.57+. He writes it out and signs it III.1.65+.

Why it matters. The confession is the play's most detailed account of the torture, and it may have been written by others.

E11 The test III.1.84–106

Roberto says the confession is false and was built from what Gerardo told him III.1.90. Paulina reveals that she planted small variations in her story to Gerardo, and Roberto corrected most of them III.1.99. She will kill him not for guilt but because he has not repented III.1.99, and counts towards ten.

Why it matters. The play hands the audience a test of guilt and then refuses to let the verdict settle.

E12 The mirror III.1.107

Paulina asks why people like her must always be the ones to make concessions III.1.107. The actors freeze and a giant mirror descends, forcing the audience to look at themselves III.1.107+.

Why it matters. The question of what she does is handed to the audience; we do not see the outcome.

Scene III.2

E13 The concert III.2.1

Months later Gerardo talks to admirers about the Commission's final report III.2.1. Roberto appears, perhaps real, perhaps an illusion III.2.1+. The quartet plays; Paulina and Roberto look at each other, and she faces the stage and the mirror III.2.1+.

Why it matters. Reconciliation is staged as a society that sits in the same room as its torturers and listens to the same music.

Characters

Paulina Salas

A survivor of detention and torture under the dictatorship, married to Gerardo; arrested on 6 April 1975 III.1.56.

- Identifies Roberto by music, voice and phrases rather than sight I.4.13.
- Demands speech, not death II.1.95, and claims the right to be heard II.1.68.
- Sets a trap that seems to prove Roberto's guilt III.1.99.
- Refuses the role of the one who always concedes III.1.107.

Arc. From hiding with a gun (I.1) to judge (II–III) to a silent figure in the concert hall (III.2).

Gerardo Escobar

A lawyer newly appointed to the president's Investigating Commission I.2.11.

- Speaks for due process and moderation, and fears for the Commission II.1.67.
- Calls Paulina mad in private II.2.39 and helps produce the confession III.1.90.
- Asks forgiveness for his affair III.1.14.

Arc. Ends successful and public III.2.1: the transition's face.

Dr Roberto Miranda

The doctor who helps Gerardo on the road and whom Paulina accuses.

- Arrives because of the Commission I.2.11.
- Explains his cassette innocently II.2.21.
- Confesses, then retracts III.1.86, and argues against the cycle of revenge III.1.104.

Arc. The play never decides him; his final appearance may be an illusion III.2.1+.

Themes

Each theme is traced through the work. Quotation numbers refer to the quote bank.

Justice, due process and revenge

The play sets a private trial against public justice that cannot reach the living. Dorfman never lets the audience settle on which is just.

Act I	The Commission investigates only deaths I.1.64. Paulina announces her own trial I.4.54. Quotations: Q1, Q4, Q7
Act II	The trial acquires procedure and terms: recording II.1.7, a defender, and a demand for confession rather than death II.1.95. Quotations: Q8, Q9, Q10, Q13, Q15
Act III	The charge moves from guilt to repentance III.1.99, and Roberto names the cycle of revenge III.1.104. The verdict is never shown. Quotations: Q23, Q24, Q25, Q27

The whole arc. From a trial the state will not hold, to a trial with no possible verdict.

Truth, memory and evidence

Paulina's evidence is sensory and remembered; Roberto's confession is coerced and possibly scripted. The play offers proof and withholds certainty.

Act I	The audience hears Roberto's Nietzsche before it means anything I.2.22; Paulina identifies him by music and voice I.4.13. Quotations: Q5, Q6
Act II	Paulina claims the right to speak II.1.68; Roberto offers innocent explanations II.2.21. Quotations: Q8, Q11, Q12, Q13, Q14
Act III	Paulina testifies III.1.52; Roberto confesses, then says the confession was written for him III.1.90; her test seems to prove him guilty III.1.99; the last stage direction leaves him real or imagined III.2.1+. Quotations: Q19, Q20, Q21, Q22, Q23, Q29

The whole arc. Each act adds evidence and each act weakens it, so the audience ends where Paulina began: certain without proof, or doubtful without reason.

Transition, the state and reconciliation

The Escobars' house is a small version of the country after dictatorship: the victim, the lawyer of the new order and the alleged agent of the old regime under one roof.

Act I	The new government's Commission is fragile I.2.39.

	Quotations: Q1, Q3, Q4
Act II	Gerardo fears the episode will destroy the Commission II.1.67. Quotations: Q10
Act III	The marriage repeats the national formula III.1.17; the final scene shows the report delivered III.2.1 while victim and torturer share a concert hall. Quotations: Q18, Q19, Q25, Q26, Q28

The whole arc. Reconciliation is shown working, and shown costing the person least able to bear it.

Gender and power

The play stages a woman's testimony judged by two men, one who loves her and one she says raped her. Who is called mad, and who repairs the damage, are recurring questions.

Act I	The first quarrel is about who fixes things I.1.10; Roberto's Nietzsche concerns the female soul I.2.22. Quotations: Q2, Q5
Act II	Gerardo protects Roberto with his body II.1.39 and calls Paulina mad in private II.2.39. Quotations: Q9, Q12, Q15
Act III	Paulina asks why people like her must always concede III.1.107. Quotations: Q16, Q27

The whole arc. Paulina holds the gun throughout and is still the one asked to give way.

Complicity and concealment

Gerardo is the play's voice of law and openness, and he deceives: in the past, by his affair, and in the present, by coaching the confession.

Act I	He keeps the details of his appointment from Paulina at first I.1.89. Quotations: –
Act II	He agrees to indulge Paulina by obtaining a confession II.2.39. Quotations: –
Act III	The affair is reopened III.1.9 and Roberto says Gerardo told him what to write III.1.90. Quotations: Q16, Q17, Q18, Q22

The whole arc. The defender of transparency is the play's most consistent concealer.

Art and atrocity

Schubert's quartet is the torturer's music and the victim's favourite. Its return in the final scene asks whether art can be shared with the people who used it.

Act I	Paulina plays the cassette taken from Roberto's car I.4.1+.

	Quotations: Q6
Act II	Roberto lists other composers to make the cassette innocent II.2.21. Quotations: –
Act III	The confession explains the music as a way to win trust III.1.57+; the play ends with the quartet in a concert hall III.2.1+. Quotations: Q21

The whole arc. Paulina wins back the music, and has to hear it in the same room as Roberto.

Theme and scene grid

Reading a row from left to right gives that theme's arc.

Theme	Act I	Act II	Act III
Justice, due process and revenge	Q1, Q4, Q7	Q8, Q9, Q10, Q13, Q15	Q23, Q24, Q25, Q27
Truth, memory and evidence	Q5, Q6	Q8, Q11, Q12, Q13, Q14	Q19, Q20, Q21, Q22, Q23, Q29
Transition, the state and reconciliation	Q1, Q3, Q4	Q10	Q18, Q19, Q25, Q26, Q28
Gender and power	Q2, Q5	Q9, Q12, Q15	Q16, Q27
Complicity and concealment			Q16, Q17, Q18, Q22
Art and atrocity	Q6		Q21

Dorfman's methods: the playscript

AO3: how the writer creates meanings and effects through language, structure and form.

Unity of place and time

One house, one night and a day: the classical unities compress a nation's transition into a room I.1, opening+.

Three characters and shifting alliances

Each scene changes who is aligned with whom: the men drinking together I.2.22, Paulina and Gerardo against each other II.1.39, the two men alone II.2.39.

The wordless scene

Act I, Scene 3 has no dialogue; the turning point is shown as an image in car headlights I.3, opening+.

Sound: music, sea and the cassette recorder

Schubert played in the house I.4.1+; the recorder as courtroom procedure II.1.7; the confession heard in darkness III.1.57+.

The mirror and the audience

A giant mirror makes the audience look at itself at the moment of decision III.1.107+, and faces the actors in the last scene III.2.1+. A Brechtian reading of this device is set out in the DATM lens file on Dorfman and Brecht.

Withheld resolution

The countdown stops before ten III.1.105; the next scene may show a ghost III.2.1+.

Motifs and symbols

The spare tyre and the nail

The first scene's quarrel about who failed to fix the spare I.1.10 becomes the reason Roberto comes back I.2.15.

Light: moon and headlights

Headlights expose Paulina in the first scene I.1, opening+ and Roberto bound in the third I.3, opening+.

The gun

Introduced before any dialogue I.1, opening+ and fired once in Act I I.4.38.

Quote bank

29 quotations in order, each checked against the text.

Scene I.1

No.	Ref.	Quotation and note
Q1	I.1.64	PAULINA: “Doesn’t it only investigate the cases that ended in death?” The limit of the state’s justice is named in the first scene: the living are outside its remit. Justice · Transition
Q2	I.1.10	PAULINA: “His wife. Always got to be the wife who has to fix everything.” A domestic quarrel about a spare tyre sets up the question of who repairs the damage. Gender and power

Scene I.2

No.	Ref.	Quotation and note
Q3	I.2.11	ROBERTO: “I heard your name on the news” The public appointment brings the stranger to the door. Transition
Q4	I.2.39	GERARDO: “the Army is going to fight the Commission all the way” The transition is shown as fragile: the old powers are still armed. Transition · Justice
Q5	I.2.22	ROBERTO: “You know what Nietzsche once wrote” A casual remark that will become evidence; the audience hears it before it means anything. Truth · Gender and power

Scene I.4

No.	Ref.	Quotation and note
Q6	I.4.13	PAULINA: “The doctor who played Schubert.” The identification is made through music, not a face. Truth · Art and atrocity
Q7	I.4.54	PAULINA: “We’re going to put him on trial, Gerardo, this doctor. Right here. Today.” The courtroom moved into a beach house: a private trial in the absence of a public one. Justice

Scene II.1

No.	Ref.	Quotation and note
Q8	II.1.7	PAULINA: "everything you say will be recorded here" The cassette recorder gives the private trial its formal procedure. Justice · Truth
Q9	II.1.39	GERARDO: "you would have to kill me too" Gerardo puts his own body between Paulina and her revenge. Justice · Gender and power
Q10	II.1.68	PAULINA: "the members of the Commission only deal with the dead" The survivor's complaint: institutions are built for those who cannot speak. Justice · Transition
Q11	II.1.68	PAULINA: "And I can speak" Four words that claim a right the play's institutions deny. Truth
Q12	II.1.79	GERARDO: "You're still a prisoner" The liberal husband diagnoses her; the line is true and also a way of not hearing her. Truth · Gender and power
Q13	II.1.95	PAULINA: "I want him to confess." She wants speech, not death: the play's demand is for an acknowledged truth. Justice · Truth

Scene II.2

No.	Ref.	Quotation and note
Q14	II.2.21	ROBERTO: "I also like Vivaldi and Mozart and Telemann" An innocent explanation, or a rehearsed one; the play leaves both open. Truth
Q15	II.2.39	GERARDO: "When crazy people have power, you've got to indulge them." The lawyer calls the victim mad and proposes to manage her. Gender and power · Justice

Scene III.1

No.	Ref.	Quotation and note
Q16	III.1.9	PAULINA: "That bitch came out of your bedroom" The private betrayal behind the public man. Complicity and concealment · Gender and power

Q17	III.1.14	**GERARDO:** "My God, I'm also human." Gerardo asks for the forgiveness he denies Paulina's need for justice. Complicity and concealment
Q18	III.1.17	**PAULINA:** "Forgive and forget, eh?" The national slogan of reconciliation, applied to the marriage. Transition · Complicity and concealment
Q19	III.1.52	**GERARDO:** "Just as if you were sitting in front of the Commission." The testimony is staged for an institution that will never hear it. Transition · Truth
Q20	III.1.54	**PAULINA:** "My maiden name is Paulina Salas." The title's "maiden" returns as her name before marriage and before arrest. Truth
Q21	III.1.57+	"I would put on Schubert because it was a way of gaining the prisoners' trust" Roberto's recorded voice. Art used as an instrument of torture; spoken in a confession whose authorship is in doubt. Art and atrocity · Truth
Q22	III.1.90	**ROBERTO:** "Your husband told me what to write" The confession is undermined by the very man who argued for due process. Truth · Complicity and concealment
Q23	III.1.99	**PAULINA:** "you corrected most of them" Her proof of guilt rests on a test the audience never hears her set. Truth · Justice
Q24	III.1.99	**PAULINA:** "because you haven't repented at all" The charge shifts from guilt to repentance, which no court can measure. Justice
Q25	III.1.104	**ROBERTO:** "So someone did terrible things to you and now you're doing something terrible to me" The argument against vengeance, made by the man she says is a torturer. Justice · Transition
Q26	III.1.106	**ROBERTO:** "Oh Paulina, isn't it time we stopped?" The plea for an end, in the language of reconciliation. Transition
Q27	III.1.107	**PAULINA:** "why always me who has to bite her tongue" The question of who pays for peace, asked by the person who has always paid. Gender and power · Justice

Scene III.2

No.	Ref.	Quotation and note
Q28	III.2.1	GERARDO: “the Final Report of the Commission” The institutional ending, announced at a social gathering. Transition
Q29	III.2.1+	“He could be real or he could be an illusion” The stage direction refuses the audience certainty about what it sees. Truth

Self-test

7 quick questions; answers with references follow.

1. **What is Gerardo appointed to?**
   A truth commission abroad / The Army / The Supreme Court / The president's Investigating Commission
2. **Why does Roberto first come to the house?**
   He gave Gerardo a lift after a flat tyre and returns with his spare / He is Paulina's doctor / He is lost / He is sent by the Army
3. **What music does Paulina associate with her torturer?**
   Mozart's Dissonant Quartet / Schubert's Death and the Maiden / Telemann / Vivaldi
4. **What does Paulina say she wants from Roberto?**
   A confession / An apology to the Commission / His death / Money
5. **How does Paulina test the confession?**
   She asked his children / She checked his car / She played the tape to Gerardo / She told Gerardo a story with small errors, and Roberto corrected them
6. **What descends at the end of Act III, Scene 1?**
   A cassette recorder / A curtain / A giant mirror / A screen with the Commission's report
7. **Where is the final scene set?**
   A concert hall, months later / A courtroom / The Commission's office / The beach house

Answers

1. The president's Investigating Commission I.2.11
2. He gave Gerardo a lift after a flat tyre and returns with his spare I.2.15
3. Schubert's Death and the Maiden I.4.1+
4. A confession II.1.95
5. She told Gerardo a story with small errors, and Roberto corrected them III.1.99
6. A giant mirror III.1.107+
7. A concert hall, months later III.2.1

Sources

- Ariel Dorfman, *Death and the Maiden* (1991).
- The iSWIM Primer on issues of significance, DATM revision notes, and the DATM lens files (justice, the individual and the state, liberty, Arendt, Kafka, Brecht).
- The iSWIM framework for Paper 2 (five guiding questions, M(A)/M(B), PEACE ACT).